

# Introduction

Founded in 1829 with the mission of creating value for society, the Technical University of Denmark (DTU) stands as an international elite technical university where education, scientific advice, and innovation are built on a foundation of world-class research. We are dedicated to developing ethically sound and sustainable technological solutions that benefit people and society. By collaborating across disciplines, industries, and borders, we aim to create value-adding technological solutions that will ensure a future where sustainability is not just a goal but a way of life<sup>1</sup>.

DTU joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in 2023. CoARA encompasses numerous interconnected agendas, and we will approach our internal reform comprehensively, considering all aspects of our operations. If new relevant areas emerge during this process, they will be incorporated. We fully recognize that researchers today are expected to excel in multiple areas and produce a variety of outputs, which must be part of a holistic approach to recognition and assessment. The CoARA principles will guide the evolution of our internal evaluation processes<sup>2</sup>. This action plan outlines the goals and activities for our initiative within the scope of CoARA.

Freedom of scientific research, research ethics, and integrity are values that guide all aspects of our scientific conduct<sup>3</sup>. We strive to foster an inclusive and impactful research environment that generate sustainable solutions to society's challenges. DTU is fully committed to the Open Science agenda, with support functions such as DTU Library and DTU Legal aiding researchers in the open sharing of results and knowledge. We have infrastructure dedicated to supporting Open Access to publications and ensuring data management according to the FAIR principles<sup>4</sup>.

DTU is committed to fostering an inclusive academic and research environment, embodied in our Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) plan developed by the Human Resources Department. The DEI plan builds on the Gender Equality Plan (GEP) adopted in 2021<sup>5</sup>. In 2025, this will be complemented by a defined effort on DEI in the research process. By embedding DEI into every aspect of our operations, we aim to promote a diverse, equitable, and inclusive culture for both students and staff. These principles are deeply integrated into DTU's research and innovation activities, central to our mission of creating a truly inclusive and innovative learning and research environment.

DTU CoARA efforts and outcomes must align with our vision, mission, and organizational context<sup>6</sup>. As part of a larger community, alignment is crucial. Reforming research assessment is a long-term endeavour that requires collaboration across the sector to develop the most suitable solutions. Inclusion of diverse perspectives and backgrounds is essential, as they contribute to the best solutions through

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<sup>1</sup> DTU Facts & Figures 2024

<sup>2</sup> coara.eu

<sup>3</sup> [The Danish Code of Conduct for Research Integrity](#)

<sup>4</sup> [Open Science at DTU Library](#)

<sup>5</sup> [DTU Diversity, Equity and Inclusion \(DEI\)](#)

<sup>6</sup> [DTU Strategy and policy](#)

broad perspectives and diversified understandings. There will be iterative adjustments until optimal solutions are found. No entity can act in isolation from the rest of the sector, and DTU will continue to engage actively with the broader community and research sector.

## DTU CoARA Project Phases

The DTU CoARA project is structured into two key phases, each designed to ensure a comprehensive and focused approach. The first phase establishes the foundation for the project, while the second involves mapping the baseline, identifying relevant processes, implementing changes, and conducting self-assessment of the effects of the changes.

### Phase 1 (year 1): Establishing Foundations and Mapping Processes

In the first phase, we focus on creating a solid foundation for the initiative. This involves setting up a governance framework, forming the Advisory and Project Groups, and mapping existing administrative processes. The goal is to identify all relevant processes and structures for analysis and change.

#### **Governance and project set-up**

To ensure commitment and integration within our organization, we will implement a flexible project structure. The initiative will be led by our Provost, supported by an Advisory Group with representatives from central administration and key stakeholders, as well as a Project Group responsible for the detailed analysis and implementation of changes.

We have defined specific milestones and deliverables to ensure progress and accountability.

#### **Advisory Group**

The Advisory Group, chaired by our Provost, will include representatives from Human Resources, research support staff, corporate communication, Heads of research departments, and researchers. The Advisory Group will advise on the initiative's scope, prioritize identified actions, and provide diverse insights into global trends and agendas in research assessment reform. The group will regularly review progress and provide input on challenges during the implementation phase.

The Advisory Group will report to the Board of Directors through the Provost and dedicated secretariat.

#### **Project Group**

The Project Group, chaired by a member of staff from the Office of Research, will consist of administrative staff members responsible for the processes and structures subject to analysis and change. This group will be dynamic, adapting to the specific stages and needs of the project. The Project Group will conduct a stakeholder analysis and map administrative processes to identify elements for analysis in alignment with CoARA principles.

The Project Group will report to the Provost, providing the mapping of relevant administrative processes and structures, overview with recommendations for change, estimates of expected outcomes, and conduct self-assessment of the effects of implemented changes. The group will also propose initiatives

to involve and engage research environments and researchers. Regular meetings will be held to review progress, address challenges, and manage risks, ensuring project continuity. The group will also explore opportunities for internal capacity-building and training initiatives, such as workshops, seminars, or informational videos.

### **Mapping**

The evaluation of research and researchers in our organization is conducted through processes distributed across multiple units. To ensure a comprehensive identification of all relevant processes and structures, the Project Group will assess all administrative procedures and frameworks. The results will be compiled into an internal overview, with proposed changes and estimates of their expected impacts. This mapping outcome will be presented to the Advisory Group for discussion and prioritization. The final decision will rest with the DTU Board of Directors. Following this decision, an operational change plan will be developed to guide the project into its next phase.

The Project Group will also propose strategies to engage our research environments and researchers. Initiatives endorsed by the Board of Directors will be implemented by the Project Group.

Milestone 1 (year 1): All relevant processes identified

Deliverable (internal): Overview of identified processes, including recommendations for change and expected outcomes.

## **Phase 2 (years 2-5): Implementing Changes and Engaging the Community**

The second phase involves developing and executing plans for changing identified processes and structures, actively engaging researchers and the research community, ensuring effective communication, and fostering collaborative networks. The goal is to implement the changes, assess their impact, and support continuous improvement and alignment with CoARA principles.

### **Plan for Change of Identified Process and Structures and Annual Review**

Based on the decisions of the Board of Directors, the Project Group will develop an operational plan for implementation. For each identified process and change, a responsible person from the responsible administrative unit will be appointed. This approach ensures that responsibility is embedded within the organisation. Each administrative unit will be responsible for implementing the change and monitoring progress and outcomes throughout the project.

To ensure continuous improvement and alignment with CoARA principles, the Project Group will conduct an annual review of the effects of implemented changes and outcomes. This review will involve a comprehensive assessment of progress, identification of areas for further improvement, and adjustments to strategies as necessary. The findings from these reviews will be documented and shared with all stakeholders to maintain transparency and foster a culture of continuous enhancement.

### **Engagement of Researchers and the Research Community**

The outcomes of CoARA will significantly impact the daily lives of researchers within our organization. It is crucial to engage and involve them to ensure that the solutions applied are tailored to our specific context and align with global developments. Many researchers within our organization are members of both national and international review committees for public and private funding bodies, directly involved in evaluating research applications. Through this work, they are exposed to various approaches to reforming research assessment. For our organization, it is important to learn from these diverse experiences and engage with funding bodies to help shape forthcoming assessment principles and structures.

### **Communication**

Engagement and transparency are essential for co-creating optimal solutions, making communication a cornerstone of this initiative. Communication will be directed both internally, to enhance knowledge of CoARA principles and agendas, and externally, to transparently share our organization's commitment and efforts. Internally, we aim to increase awareness and understanding, while externally, we will demonstrate our alignment with CoARA principles. The Action Plan and the self-assessment in year five will be openly shared with the community on Zenodo.

### **Network**

The collective understanding of this theme is continually evolving, making it vital for our organization to follow the discourse, emerging trends, and collective learning to draw inspiration from best practices. Being part of this movement and closely following developments is essential. Our organization already actively engages in forums, networks, and organizations where CoARA's various agendas have been discussed for many years, and these efforts will continue. Additionally, DTU will closely monitor CoARA working groups to leverage relevant insights and communications that enhance our organizational knowledge and understanding of CoARA.

DTU will actively participate in new national initiatives and have supported the establishment of a national network that includes the broad Danish sector of universities and private and public funding bodies. DTU fully supports the development of this network into a Danish national CoARA chapter. DTU is committed to several international university alliances, and will actively engage in mutual inspiration, knowledge exchange, and activities within these alliances.

Milestone 2 (year 5): Changes implemented and effects assessed

Deliverable: Self-assessment of the effect of implemented changes